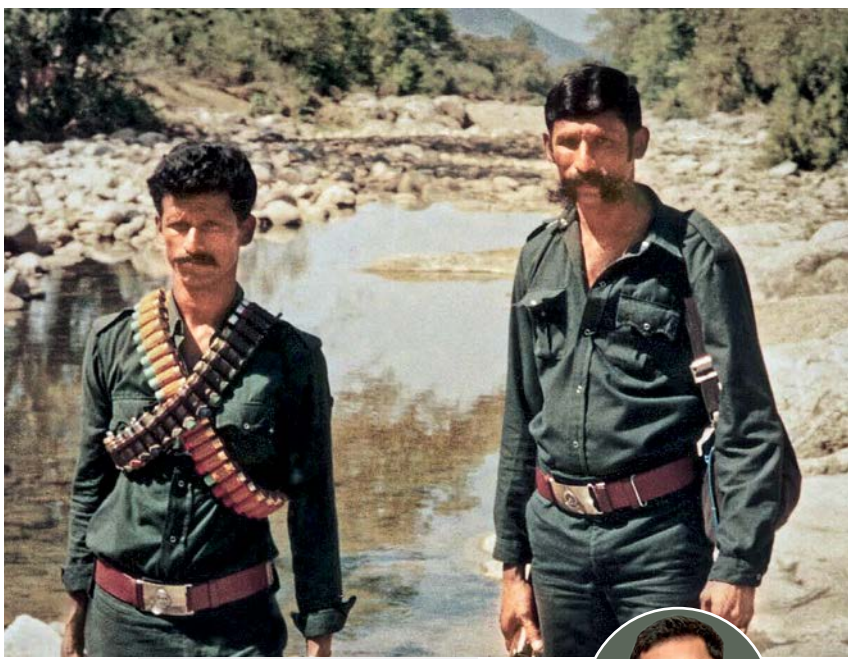
DOCUMENTARY

THE BANDIT KING

A Netflix documentary on sandalwood smuggler Veerappan throws light on his fascinating life–and death





Poacher, smuggler, brigand, killer, kidnapper, a self-proclaimed vigilante and revolutionary, India's most wanted.... Veerappan was many things and still an enigma. Netflix's latest non-fiction series, *The Hunt for Veerappan*, attempts to dissect why the man, despite his litany of crimes, was revered by many. Taking the talking heads format, director Selvamani Selvaraj gives multiple perspectives to create a captivating portrait.

What the four-episode series covering nearly two decades brings out well is the strange dichotomy of being Veerappan. Notorious for his ecocide in Sathyamangalam forest–his gang killed hundreds of elephants and destroyed countless sandalwood trees–he was also someone in sync with the forest, earning the label 'forest king'. Using it as his refuge, he evaded the police of Tamil Nadu and Karnataka for nearly 15 years. "The story of his spirit to survive kept us fascinated," says Selvaraj. "The fact that he could live for 10,000 nights in the forest and not leave a trace behind was impressive." When Selvaraj began his research in 2018, he was thinking of taking the fictional route, making the "*Narcos* of Sathyamangalam forest". But as he began interviewing those associated with Veerappan, he felt non-fiction was the way to go. It ended up being a wise move given the wealth of voices Selvaraj has at his disposal. Over a year and a half, Selvaraj and his team of researchers, including two journalists, reached out to officials from the forest department and the special task force appointed to nab him, to residents from his village, Gopinanthan. "We knew people were not just going to tell the story," says Selvaraj. "With those who do, you have to build a bond, so that they open up. It took some time to understand that the show was choosing the people."

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The one who required the most work to get on board and ends up being the star of the show is Veerappan's wife, Muthulakshmi. As she defends his actions and recounts episodes of his Houdini act with a smile, she offers a side of Veerappan few know of, through audio tapes that he sent to her. They make for some of the most riveting bits in the documentary.

Selvaraj, though, is clear in his mission to highlight the brutality of his subject. But he is also not afraid to touch on how the "police and Veerappan were feeding off each other", creating a turbulent period during which innumerable lives were lost and a fear of both the big-moustached brigand and officers in camouflage enveloped the region. For all of Veerappan's claims about helping the poor, it's they who suffered the most during his reign of terror. ■

Suhani Singh